



YALONDA M. JAMES - yjames@charlotteobserver.com

Mathias Engelmann, director of rehabilitation, holds a bird as Dave Scott examines its eyes at the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville.

Raptor Center to expand programs

Huntersville group has hired its first on-staff veterinarian

BY LENA WARMACK

Lwarmack@charlotteobserver.com

HUNTERSVILLE — The Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville will expand its educational and teaching programs with the help of its first on-staff veterinarian.

David Scott joined the center this week and will help develop instructional programs that include internships for students, training seminars for veterinarians and weeklong crash courses on raptor medicine.

"Educating the people is one important aspect of this job," said 42-year-old Scott, who moved to Lake Norman from Charleston. "A lot of this is going to be teaching."

The nonprofit bird refuge — which

SEE RAPTOR | 2N



Scott

More programs at center

Raptor from 1N

treats and rehabilitates injured birds of prey such as hawks, eagles and owls on 57 acres off Sample Road — wants to develop a reputation as a learning hub.

"This is a major milestone for this organization. We've never had a full-time vet," said Jim Warren, chief operating officer for the center.

In the past, the center relied on volunteer veterinarians to conduct surgery and provide medical treatments for the birds. And seminars were led by the rehabilitation staff.

Scott will design and teach classes and labs and create coursework material for visiting college students who want to earn college credit. He will also provide on-site medical care for the growing number of birds of prey — about 600 to 800 annually — that visit the center for treatment.

In the past, birds were transported to local animal hospitals for care, Engelmann said.

"It's a stressful situation for our birds," said Mathias Engelmann, director of rehabilitation for the center. "Giving them the level of care they need just isn't feasible moving them off site."

Engelmann said the center considered 10 applicants before selecting Scott, who was well-liked for his strong teaching skills and experience.

Scott, who has worked as electrical engineer and has spent 10 years as a veterinarian, earned his doctorate in veterinary medicine from the Univer-

Explore the Carolina Raptor Center

■ **Location:** 6000 Sample Road in Huntersville.

■ **Admission:** \$7, adults; \$6, seniors 60 and up; \$5, students. Free for members and children under 5.

■ **Hours:** 10 a.m.-5 p.m. Mondays to Saturdays; noon-5 p.m. Sundays.

■ **Details:** www.carolinaraptor-center.org or call 704-875-6521.

— SOURCE: CAROLINA RAPTOR CENTER

sity of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign in 1997.

He developed an interest in raptors from his encounters with them as a volunteer at raptor centers.

"I fell in love with them," he said. "Birds of prey are engineeringly perfect."

The center was formed in the 1980s by a group of UNC Charlotte students and biology faculty who wanted to treat and protect raptors.

Today, 23 species of raptors are housed at the center and more than 40,000 people visit the center annually.

At the Raptor Center, Scott said, he hopes to encourage people to protect the environment and wildlife.

"We can treat one bird at a time, but if we can educate society as a whole to respect birds of prey and the environment," Scott said, "hopefully, we'll be preventing the problems from ever happening instead of treating it after the fact."

Lena Warmack: 704-987-3670, ext. 14.

Charlotte Observer

6/5/08